Taylor & Francis
Taylor & Francis Group

Journal of Southern African Studies

'Individualism is the Antithesis of Indirect Rule': Cooperative Development and Indirect Rule in Colonial Malawi
Author(s): Joey Power
Reviewed work(s):
Source: *Journal of Southern African Studies*, Vol. 18, No. 2 (Jun., 1992), pp. 317-347
Published by: Taylor & Francis, Ltd.
Stable URL: http://www.jstor.org/stable/2637271
Accessed: 21/11/2012 09:37

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at
http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Taylor & Francis, Ltd. and *Journal of Southern African Studies* are collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Journal of Southern African Studies.*

http://www.jstor.org

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Journal of Southern African Studies, Vol. 18, No. 2, June 1992

'Individualism is the Antithesis of Indirect Rule':[1] *Cooperative Development and Indirect Rule in Colonial Malawi**

JOEY POWER
(History Department, Ryerson Polytechnical Institute, Toronto, Canada)

The introduction of cooperatives and indirect rule to colonial Malawi during the 1930s was part of an exercise in imperial social engineering designed to thwart class formation. As early as the Chilembwe rising of 1915, officials had drawn the connection between petit bourgeois *frustration and violence. In 1915, the state's response was to strengthen 'tribal authority' in rebel districts, leaving the* petit bourgeoisie *in the political wilderness. In the 1930s officials believed that, in addition to economic benefits, indirect rule, and later, cooperatives, would pay political dividends: indirect rule, by enhancing rural administration, and cooperatives, by diverting the political energies of the African* petit bourgeoisie *into collective economic endeavour. Yet neither indirect rule nor cooperatives were able to impede the process of class formation. In the south, cooperatives met with failure, either for lack of interest, distrust of government initiatives, or because certain members hijacked them for individual economic ends. Just as indirect rule was embraced by 'Native Authorities' because it enhanced their chances of individual accumulation, cooperatives were rejected by the African* petit bourgeoisie *because they did not.*

Introduction

In July 1952 the Cooperative Officer, H.F. Bingham, lamented that he had never 'come across, anywhere in the Southern Province [of Nyasaland], a group of people who [had] shown the slightest managerial ability'.[2] Cooperatives never became a popular form of economic organisation in the Southern Province of colonial Malawi. As of 10 March 1949 a mere seven were in operation and total

[1] [M]alawi [N]ational [A]rchives, Zomba, NS1/3/12, F97, Minute: Chief Secretary Ken Hall, 11 July 1931.

* Thanks go to Martin Klein, Phil Zachernuk, Steve Rockell and Megan Vaughan for their helpful criticism. I am also grateful to the Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada which provided partial funding for this research.

[2] MNA, AS/6/5507, 'Order for Dissolution', 16 April 1951.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

membership stood at only 274 persons.[3] Yet Bingham's explanation for this was all too pat. Many of Blantyre and Zomba districts' early 'cooperators' were educated government clerical workers or company employees and many were, or became, private business people. As employees, as proprietors of their own shops or firms, as consumers or tax-payers, these people were exposed to and understood non-African society — its government and its business practices. They were sound business people who were quick to recognize that cooperatives undercut the economic autonomy of individuals, depriving them of a crucial edge in an economy dominated by foreign capital and characterized by cut-throat competition. Hence, it was a familiarity with the colonial economic system and a desire to compete effectively in it which led Africans to reject the cooperative option.

What follows is as much the story of a failed experiment in imperial social engineering as it is an account of the demise of the cooperative movement in Nyasaland. It falls into a larger body of writing which deals with the contradictions and ambiguities of indirect rule and the creation of tribalism in colonial Malawi.[4] It is my suggestion that the cooperative movement and indirect rule policy were linked and premised upon several false assumptions held by officials about African 'communalism'. Both were intensely imperialistic projects meant to direct and control the development of emerging classes. The introduction of indirect rule and cooperatives were part and parcel of a general trend toward greater government control of Nyasaland's economy and society.

Plans for a cooperative movement in Nyasaland came out of deliberations conducted in the 1930s concerning how best to regulate labour migration. Officials hoped that credit, producer and marketing cooperatives would serve as economic alternatives to migration by providing a structure for pooling African savings and encouraging productive investment at home. It soon became clear that officials felt cooperatives might pay political dividends as fitting adjuncts to indirect rule. Both indirect rule and coops were to be important instruments used to resuscitate the old 'tribal' order which officials believed was under attack by the evil forces of individualism born of migration and the cash economy. Indirect rule would strengthen the power of chiefs and headmen in rural areas and cooperatives would divert the political ambitions of an emerging African capitalist class.

In the south, cooperatives were clearly directed towards distracting that disaffected African *petit-bourgeois* element which had been so important to the Chilembwe rising of 1915.[5] Landeg White has argued convincingly that the anti-colonial

---

[3] MNA, Ministry of Trade and Industry, Native Cooperatives, File No. 14019/7883, F26, Bingham to Fox-Strangways, Secretary of State for African Affairs, 10 March 1949.

[4] Landeg White '"Tribes"and the Aftermath of the Chilembwe Rising of 1915', *African Affairs*, 84 (1984), pp. 511-541; Leroy Vail and Landeg White, 'Tribalism in the Political History of Malawi', in Leroy Vail (ed.), *The Creation of Tribalism in Southern Africa* (London, 1989), pp. 151-192; Tony Woods, 'Capitãos and Chiefs: Oral Tradition and Colonial Society in Malawi', *The International Journal of African Historical Studies*, 23, 2(1990), pp. 259-268; M.L. Chanock, 'Ambiguities in the Malawian Political Tradition', *African Affairs*, 296 (1975), pp. 326-346.

[5] I use the term 'petit bourgeois' here to denote economic position. Those people who fall into this category were petit bourgeois in so far as they frequently held down jobs while at the same time ran their own businesses, often employing wage labourers. They were also commonly products of

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

violence of the rebellion was critical in speeding the implementation of indirect rule in southern Nyasaland.[6] The imposition of the District Administration Natives Ordinance of 1912 strengthened the authority of the chiefs, leaving the African *petit bourgeoisie* in the political wasteland. Subsequent efforts to widen the political participation of this group were no more than token.[7] It was through the various Native Associations, formed in the years immediately before and after the First World War, that petit bourgeois Africans voiced their concerns. In the main, this group eschewed radical politics and concentrated on personal uplift through white-collar employment, self-employment or a combination of the two. In spite of the decidedly benign characteristics of their politics, the state continued to be nervous about the political potential of the African *petit bourgeoisie*.

The cooperative movement in the south was an attempt to impose a new economic order on *petit-bourgeois* commerce. Even though initial discussion of cooperatives suggested a preference for agricultural producer societies, it was not the peasantry which was targeted for the first experiments in Southern Province; rather, it was the African white collar workers and entrepreneurs. These were the people with whom the man in charge, H.F. Bingham, felt most comfortable. They were commercially ambitious, literate and concentrated in the urban and peri-urban areas. Hence, organising them would be easier and would not conflict with the European plantation sector or draw labour away from the indirect rulers who were busily capitalising on the cheap labour of dependent country folk. Finally, 'cooperatising' the southern *petit bourgeoisie* would support indirect rule by diverting its energies away from politics and into state monitored commerce.

A masterful plan, so what went awry? Simply stated, while the officials recognized the emergence of new class divisions and sought to temper and direct them, they did not fully understand the implications of their solutions. Indirect rule was as much a divisive force and an antagonist of egalitarianism as it was an inhibitor of class formation. Strengthening chiefs frequently intensified rural

---

mission schooling, but this is not so of later entrepreneurs (1940s and 1950s), whom I also include in this economic category because of the way in which they oscillate between waged work and self-employment. 'Straddling' (a term coined by Michael Cowen and applied to the colonial Kenyan case by Gavin Kitching) usually involved white collar workers investing in rural ventures. In southern Nyasaland, 'straddlers' often invested in urban businesses. This was particularly so after World War Two. Moreover, this group of individuals were not all western-educated. The self-employed artisans, traders and transporters seldom had formal education beyond Standards Two or Three, if they attended at all. It was often because they could not afford mission education that they moved into self-employment. See, Michael Cowen and K. Kinyanjui, 'Some Problems of Income Distribution in Kenya', Institute for Development Studies, Nairobi University, Discussion Paper, 1977 and Gavin Kitching, *Class and Economic Change in Kenya: the Making of an African Petite Bourgeoisie, 1905-1970* (New Haven, 1980).

[6] White '"Tribes"', pp. 526-533.

[7] In the 1920s the 'educated' elite were given slightly greater representation on District Council of chiefs and headmen which were, in any case, advisory bodies. MNA, S1/3263/23, Assistant Superintendent, CID to Chief Commissioner of Police, 15 May 1924; and Foreign and Commonwealth Office Library, Evidence of the Hilton Young Commission, evidence of J.C. Abraham, 21 March 1928, cited in Tony Woods, 'Accumulation and Order: State and Society in Colonial Malawi, 1891-1929', Michigan State University, Ph.D., 1991, p. 256.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

hostilities and inequities.[8] It gave them greater powers than they had enjoyed hitherto and greater room for the manipulation of 'custom' for their own political and economic ends.[9] Indirect rulers used their newly acquired authority for self-enrichment and, by the 1940s, labour migration became the single-most important means of escape from rural poverty and elder control for land hungry southern males. Hence, a policy which was designed to reinforce 'tribal stability', encourage respect for 'tradition' and constrain the development of pernicious individualism, in effect, accomplished the reverse.

If indirect rule was a misconceived attempt to turn the clock back (to resurrect an old, albeit imaginary, 'tribal' order), cooperatives were meant to provide an emerging capitalist class with a new 'collectivised' way forward. What officials did not bargain for was that 'cooperators' would have such a radically different conception of what economic progress meant to them. Like indirect rule chiefs, they cast their economic interests in intensely individualistic moulds, in part because economic advance was a way of reducing the hold of the gerontocracy and, in part, because up to the 1940s, African commerce received no assistance from the state. In fact, state policy inhibited individual accumulation along capitalist lines and, to a large extent, bred distrust of official involvement in African business. Chiefs and headmen enthusiastically embraced indirect rule because it served their individual aspirations; African entrepreneurs in southern province rejected cooperatives because they did not. Cooperatives worked against individual accumulation and managerial decision making and, consequently, failed to meet the needs of an aspiring capitalist class. It was for this reason that cooperatives failed in southern Malawi during the colonial period.

It was not collective action *per se* to which Africans objected. As early as the 1910s, African business people had undertaken collective self-help projects. They did so in response to an intransigent government which ignored their pleas for economic parity with European planters and traders. The economic problems which *petit-bourgeois* Africans faced in the first few decades of colonialism persisted into the late colonial period. Cooperatives offered no solution to them. Neither indirect rule nor the cooperative movement produced the results that colonial officials desired, but the explanation for this was neither African incompetence (as some believed), nor 'miscommunication' (as architects of indirect rule opined). The outcomes of both initiatives resulted from the divergent interests of the state and the people it sought to control.

---

8 According to Megan Vaughan's reading of Clyde Mitchell's 1949 village survey conducted at Domasi, various headmen there had been able to accumulate large land holdings under terms approaching individual tenure. Mitchell's survey is contained in MNA, MP 12036, and cited in Megan Vaughan, '"Better, Happier and Healthier Citizens": the Domasi Community Development Scheme, 1949-54', Chancellor College History Department Seminar Paper No. 4, 1983, pp. 7-8.

9 Martin Chanock, 'A Peculiar Sharpness: an Essay on Property in the History of Customary Law in Colonial Africa', *Journal of African History*, 31 (1991), p. 72.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Independent Africans

Frederick Lugard, the architect of indirect rule in British Africa, considered Europeanized Africans (those exposed to Western education and religion) to pose a special challenge to the imperial project. While their 'progress' was laudable, their claim to political responsibility, in his view, was not supportable because they were not representative of the illiterate masses, so divorced were they from their culture.[10] Were Africa to develop 'along its own lines' the locus of political change lay among the 'traditional' elite. The role that 'progressive' Africans were to play in indirect rule was ambiguous. In Nyasaland of the 1920s, this was no less the case.

Unlike in British West Africa, Central African elites could not count many journalists, doctors, lawyers and magistrates among their number. The church there was the first, and until the Second World War, the only 'Western' institution in which Africans might hope to gain positions of influence.[11] Hence, in colonial Malawi, the educated elite and anti-colonial protest led by that group tended to have strong Christian overtones.[12] But while many of the African elite got their start at the missions, not all pursued religious vocations. In addition to lay-missionaries and evangelists, mission graduates parleyed their education into civil service employment or white collar work in the private sector. Moreover, by 1914, Nyasaland could claim a significant number of self-employed tradesmen, planters and businessmen.[13] These were men like Haya Peters Mlelemba, a 'jack of all

[10] Lord Frederick Lugard, *The Dual Mandate in British Tropical Africa*, [first published 1923] (London, 1965), pp. 72, 84.

[11] For example, the Reverends Harry K. Matecheta of Blantyre and Stephen Kundecha of Domasi were ordained by the Church of Scotland in 1911. In 1916, Thomas Masseah of Blantyre (and of PTK Industries), Joseph Kaunde of Mlanje and Harry Ntuwa of Zomba were also ordained. Other notable African missionaries and evangelists were trained at Blantyre Mission and many more went out to spread the gospel under the auspices of the Seventh Day Adventists, the Seventh Day Baptists and other missions. Blantyre Mission also trained people in trades and so many of the independent artisans and traders got their early education there. See, G. Shepperson and T. Price, *Independent African. John Chilembwe and the Origins, Setting and Significance of the Nyasaland Native Rising of 1915* (Edinburgh, 1958); Lewis Mataka Bandawe (edited by Bridglal Pachai), *Memoirs of a Malawian. The Life and Reminiscences of Lewis Mataka Bandawe, M.B.E.* (Blantyre, 1971), pp. 34-54. Bandawe, himself, was sent out as a lay-preacher to Mozambique.

[12] There is a huge literature on how Christianity often served as a smoke screens for politics. See, for example, Karen Fields, *Revival and Rebellion in Colonial Central Africa* (Princeton, 1985); Shepperson and Price, *Independent African*; Landeg White, *Magomero, Portrait of a Village* (Cambridge, 1987); R.I. Rotberg, 'Psychological Stress and the Question of Identity: Chilembwe's Revolt Reconsidered', in Rotberg (ed.), *Rebellion in Black Africa* (London, 1971), pp. 133-163 and 'Resistance and Rebellion in British Nyasaland and German East Africa, 1888-1915: a Tentative Comparison', Prosser Gifford and William Roger Louis (eds.) with the assistance of Alison Smith, *Britain and Germany in Africa, Imperial Rivalry and Colonial Rule* (London, 1967), pp. 667-690; J. Chaphadzika Chakanza, 'Sectarianism in Joseph Booth's Mission Foundations, 1925-1975: the Search for Causative Factors', Chancellor College History Department Seminar Paper No. 15, 1985/86. For South Africa, see, Wallace G. Mills, 'The Taylor Revival of 1866 and the Roots of African Nationalism in the Cape Colony', *Journal of Religion in Africa*, 8 (1978) and 'The Fork in the Road', *Journal of Religion in Africa*, 9 (1979).

[13] John McCracken chronicles the lives of three of these — Tom Boquito, Donald Malota and Frederick Njilima in '"Marginal Men": the Colonial Experience in Malawi', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 15, 4 (1989), pp. 537- 564. Lewis Bandawe also offers an account of many African

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

trades' who moved from paid employment into self-employment, dabbled in numerous occupations including prospecting, ivory hunting and planting. A brief examination of Mlelemba's life provides a window on the career path of *petit-bourgeois* African men.

Mlelemba appears in the official files in a 1918 security report.[14] Doubtless the report was compiled because of Mlelemba's close association with Chilembwe and his co-conspirators. The Resident concluded that 'Peters', as Mlelemba preferred to be called, was 'arrogant' but not 'subversive', and uncommonly talented in commerce and literacy. The report stated that Edward H. Peters Mlelemba was a Yao, born along the Tchiri River above Chikwawa. He moved to Chilingani while still a boy. He was first educated at the Zambezi Industrial Mission (Z.I.M.) and later transferred to the Blantyre Mission (where he probably first met John Chilembwe who also schooled there in the late nineteenth century). He worked as a table boy at Keillers Hotel, as an office boy at the Z.I.M. and in 1906 did clerical work for the Blantyre Building Company. In 1909 he began work with Bartlett, Ryan and Ryall as a mineral prospector until they formed the Liwadzi Syndicate. Sometime before 1913, Peters returned to Blantyre and began market gardening on land at Nangafuwe which he rented from the Blantyre and East Africa Company. It was probably at this time that Mlelemba joined forces with Thomas Masseah and John Gray Kufa (hanged for his part in the rising) to form P.T.K. Industries, a sawyering outfit based at Nsoni.[15]

Mlelemba and others like him enjoyed considerable prosperity. In the early years of the Protectorate, they lived in material conditions equivalent to those of many white planters and traders, owning land, houses and small businesses. Joseph Bismarck, for example, owned an estate at Namwili and, in addition to sawyering, sold provisions to Keillers and Central Hotels in Blantyre. He was also an elder of the Scots Mission in Blantyre. Duncan Njilima owned land at Chiradzulu and ran a store in Blantyre. P.G. Somanje of Zomba had estates and small trading stores. Gordon and Hugh Mataka were shop-owners and land-owners. All had been educated at Blantyre Mission.[16] After the Chilembwe rising, the amount of property confiscated from the Matakas, Njilimas, Kufas and others prompted one European volunteer to remark on the number of 'swell natives in Central Africa'.[17]

---

notables in his *Memoirs*, pp. 58-62. Terms like 'businessmen' are not meant to be gender neutral. The individuals under discussion were all male.

[14] Information pertaining to Mlelemba's early life was found in a security report sent to the Superintendent of Native Affairs in 1918. Officials knew of Mlelemba's close relationship with Chilembwe and suspected that he may have been a co-conspirator. (MNA, NSB3/12/2, Acting Resident Blantyre to Superintendent of Native Affairs, 15 November 1918.) Chief Kuntaja's estate was called 'Chilingani' but the connection between him and Mlelemba has not been made to date.

[15] Bandawe, *Memoirs*, p. 60.

[16] Ibid., pp. 60-62.

[17] W. Sanderson, 'A Planter's Experiences in the Nyasaland Rising [letter from Willie Sanderson] Gotha Estate, Nyasaland, 7th Feb. 1915', cited in Shepperson and Price, *Independent African*, pp. 246, 247.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

As implied by the preceding comment, those men who had engaged in 'European style' agriculture and commerce were disdained by certain members of white society. Nevertheless, they had a strong sense that they were entitled to the same respect and privilege due all Christian men in the Protectorate and operated within the colonial structure to ensure this.[18] Again, Mlelemba's experience is instructive. In 1913, he initiated legal proceedings against Martin and Ryall. He sued them for £700, but received a settlement of only £47. The Resident's report does not provide details concerning the case. Neither does a record of it appear in the Law Reports for 1913. One suspects the case was settled out of court for reasons which remain obscure.[19] Mlelemba's willingness to go to court is suggestive of his sense of equality and, perhaps, his faith in the system.

What is most intriguing about this episode is that it has entered into the realm of urban folk lore. Quite by accident, during an interview on small business, the name of Peters Mlelemba came up. My informant related, with humour and relish, a story concerning a conflict between Mlelemba (whom he knew of mainly through reputation) and Ryall.[20] According to this account, Mlelemba lent Ryall some money for the construction of the Ryall's Hotel.[21] Ryall was to repay the full sum with interest and, in addition, had promised to give his daughter in marriage to Mlelemba. Mlelemba then went off to German East Africa to hunt elephants. While he was away, Ryall refused to repay the loan or give up his daughter and Mlelemba was incarcerated in Tanganyika on charges connected to the Chilembwe rising. He returned to Nyasaland after some time and was employed as an interpreter for Magistrate W.J.C. Jennings at Blantyre *boma*. This account depicts Mlelemba as a kind of martyr figure who was 'tricked' by a conspiracy of European official and commercial interests. At least that was the tone in which the story was related. By focusing on the marriage agreement, the informant alluded to Mlelemba's aspirations to social equality with whites and the kind of response this elicited from them. The narrator believed Mlelemba to have been the equal of Ryall and felt his incarceration an obvious betrayal. In this account, Mlelemba maintains the moral high ground even though he lost the battle.

While the two accounts differ in detail (there is no corroboration of the alleged betrothal), certain essential elements are confirmed by each. Both agree that the dispute was over money, specifically an amount owed Mlelemba by Ryall. Both accounts agree that Mlelemba threatened Ryall with legal action. Both confirm that Ryall owed him a significant amount of money. The circumstances in which the debt was incurred are unclear. But whether Mlelemba had lent Ryall money or whether Ryall owed him back wages (from the prospecting venture), it is clear that

[18] According to Landeg White, John Gray Kufa, one of the men later hanged for his involvement in the Chilembwe rising, endorsed the suspect methods of labour recruiters, Messrs. Sinderam and Walker, at the turn of the century. He and Reverend Hetherwick of Blantyre Mission allegedly assisted in 'persuading the Lomwe to accept' the terms offered for settlement in the area, that is, that they either provide recruiters with labourers or 'go to war'. White, '"Tribes"', p. 514.

[19] MNA NSB3/12/2, Acting Resident Blantyre to Superintendent of Native Affairs, 15 November 1918.

[20] Personal communication, N. Mbekeani, Limbe, 8 June 1988.

[21] This is unlikely since the hotel opened only in 1925.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Mlelemba was in a position to have earned or lent a substantial sum of money and that he did not shrink from bringing charges against anyone in order to recover it.[22] A glance through the Court Records shows that increasingly Africans were using the colonial courts as a forum for settling of property claims against Europeans.[23]

But the reality of colonialism in Malawi meant that Mlelemba and men like him, no matter how accomplished, were not accorded the same rights as whites. They faced the racism and discrimination of the colonial system head on. African planters competed unequally for labour; African entrepreneurs of all types paid higher taxes than African workers; they had unequal access to leasehold land and were banned from establishing trading outlets in urban areas and the state limited African access to credit by law. And all Africans suffered the indignities of a *de facto* colour bar.[24]

The most serious of impediments for African planters in Blantyre and Chiradzulu Districts was discriminatory access to labour. Any hopes that African planters would be treated in the same way as their European counterparts were dispelled in 1901 with the introduction of the labour certificate system.[25] To encourage people to work on white estates, the government introduced labour certificates which, if signed by a white planter, in exchange for labour services, entitled the holder to a reduced rate of tax. Africans were not permitted to endorse labour certificates since it was alleged that they would sign the receipts of relatives and friends, whether they had provided labour or not. This placed them at a considerable disadvantage with respect to labour recruitment. In 1912 and 1913, African planters in

[22] It is well known that Mlelemba loaned John Chilembwe £50 in 1908. The loan was attested by a promissory note stipulating interest payments which amounted to one shilling on the pound per month! When the store went bankrupt and Chilembwe fell behind on payments, Mlelemba threatened to bring him to law. In 1914, Chilembwe finally settled his debt but not before paying out £42 in interest, a king's ransom for the time! In 1912, African government clerical staff earned between £6 and £60 per year! Figures for skilled agricultural workers in 1914 would not have exceeded £4 per year. In 1921, builders and carpenters on estates received, on average, 12 to 30 shillings per month and unskilled wet season workers received 8 shillings per month. ([P]ublic [R]ecords [O]ffice, Kew, London, CO525/42, Manning to Secretary of State, 13 April 1912; *Nyasaland Protectorate Blue Book*, 1921 (Zomba, 1922), p. W1; Rotberg, 'Psychological stress', p. 157; see also, MNA, S10/1/8/3, the Private Papers of H.E. Peters [Mlelemba].)

[23] Cases brought by Africans against Europeans (and other Africans) numbered in the scores in Blantyre District by the late 1910s and most of them concerned small debts. See MNA, BA1/2/1 to BA1/2/4, Blantyre District Native Court-Civil Cases, 1911-1919.

[24] On access to land see, Clement Ng'ong'ola, 'The State, Settlers, and Indigenes in the Evolution of Land Law and Policy in Colonial Malawi', *The International Journal of African Historical Studies*, 23, 2 (1990), p. 41; *The Crown Lands Ordinance 1912*, No. 18 of 1912, 8 November 1912; in *Ordinances of the Nyasaland Protectorate in force on the 31 March 1913* (London, 1913), pp. 425-436. African residence in Blantyre and Limbe townships was restricted to domestic quarters as early as 1910. (GN2/10, *Blantyre Town Council Rules*, 18 January 1910.) In 1911, this was amended such that Africans were not to 'settle, carry on trade, or acquire any real or leasehold interest in the Township except in the Asiatic ward'. Generally, however, Africans found rents in town high and since they were not permitted to live there, township shops were not viable. GN5/11, 17 January 1911. Credit in excess of 10 shillings could not be recovered from an African by a non-African creditor. This limit was raised in 1926 to 20 shillings, in 1936 to £10 and to £30 in 1950. (*The Credit Trade with Natives Ordinance*, Chap. 28, 1903 and subsequent amendment ordinances, No. 15 of 1926, No. 27 of 1936 and No.23 of 1950.)

[25] White, *Magomero*, p. 87.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Chiradzulu signed petitions protesting against this discrimination.[26] It was not long before protest went beyond Chiradzulu. Joseph Bismarck of Blantyre District submitted a petition of some fifty signatures asking that African employers be allowed to endorse labour certificates.[27] These demands were ignored.

Petitions and deputations represented only one type of response to discrimination. Bismarck and others explored collective action to combat the negative effects of colonial legislation and promote African commerce. As early as April 1909, Joseph Bismarck and Haya Peters Mlelemba called a meeting to discuss the formation of a Native Industrial Union.[28] The organisation was to provide an institutional framework for the merging of African savings and expertise in the interests of forming an independent source of capital for African commercial ventures. The impetus for the Union came from interested planters and business people such as Bismarck, A.M. Chisuse (a photographer), James G. Kuuji Mlanga, Justin K. Somanje and Peters Mlelemba. They were joined at May and August meetings by Cedric Massangano (the headmaster of Blantyre Mission), John Gray Kufa Mpantha and Reverend Thomas M. Massea of the Church of Scotland in Blantyre (both of P.T.K. Industries), Harry K. Matecheta (later an ordained minister of the Church of Scotland Mission), Asher M. Matipwile, Moses Matache, Nelson Kabweza, Morris Chilembwe, John Wesley Mlanga (civil servant and Blantyre Mission adherent), Ardwell Mlenga (Church of Scotland), Ruben N. Funsani (a shop-keeper), David Livingstone (owner of a sawyering business), Kalindi Morrison Malinki (Seventh Day Adventist), D.B.O. Chinyama (also Seventh Day Adventist), Charles Scott Kwikanda and Stephen Nsomo.[29] The Union was to encourage 'the promotion and protection of Negroes, Christian work in the Country, the collecting and recording of commercial information and ... the establishment of a Court of Arbitration [and] ... Communication with the public Authorities on subjects affecting the Commercial and Planting Community, or such other things as occasion may require'.[30] In a sense, the Union was to serve as the African counterpart to the settlers' Nyasaland Associated Chamber of Agriculture and Commerce, formed in 1907.[31] The Native Industrial Union was not

---

[26] District Commissioner Wyatt reported that a number of Africans employers had approached him for permission to sign labour certificates and that he was inclined to grant this right and to allow African planters to pay the lower rate of tax themselves. His advice was ignored. The 1913 petition includes the signatures of Gordon and Hugh Mataka, Duncan Njilima, John Gray Kufa and John Chilembwe, all of whom were involved in the 1915 rising. MNA, NSB7/3/1, Monthly report for Chiradzulu sub-district, August 1912. MNA, NSB 7/3/1, monthly report Chiradzulu sub-district, 14 September 1913, cited in White, '"Tribes"', note 20, p. 520.

[27] According to Lewis Bandawe, the petition was sent to the same Governor who fell out with Chilembwe, Governor Smith. Since Smith's term of office stretched from 1913 to 1923, the petition must have been sent between 1913 and 1915. (Bandawe, *Memoirs*, p. 62.)

[28] The details reported in this paragraph are taken from Rotberg, 'Psychological Stress', pp. 152-153 and MNA, S10/1/8/3, Private Papers of H.E. Peters [Mlelemba].

[29] A list of participants can be found in MNA, S10/1/8/3, Mlelemba Papers for 30 May 1909 and 14 August 1909.

[30] Rotberg, 'Psychological Stress', p. 152.

[31] The Shire Highlands Planter's Association and the Nyasaland Planters' Association were formed to represent European planting interests in 1892. They were replaced by the British Central Africa Chamber of Agriculture and Commerce in 1895. The planters formed their own organisation,

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

to be run as a cooperative. Its membership was limited and yearly dues were set at £5. Voting rights in the organisation were also calculated according to the value of monthly fees paid.[32] In this respect also, the Native Industrial Union resembled the European Planters' Associations.

The Native Industrial Union was reincarnated as the African Industrial Society two years later. A leaflet printed on the Blantyre Mission press describing the aims and objectives of the African Industrial Society was distributed to some fifty prospective members who met at Chilembwe's Providence Industrial Mission in July of 1911. The African Industrial Society 'charter' was consistent with the schedule for the objectives of the African Christian Union inspired by John Chilembwe's mentor, Joseph Booth, some twenty years earlier. This model, proposed by Booth and endorsed by Chilembwe and Morrison Malinki in 1897, suggests that the African Industrial Society was to operate like a limited company with individual planters supplying share capital. Shareholders were to receive 'a moderate rate of interest only'. While Booth remarked that companies had been responsible for much evil work in Africa, there was no reason why the company structure could not be used for African uplift — 'working with the natives in a Christian spirit and for distinctly Christian ends'. In his view, the African Development Society (the economic arm of the Christian Union) would invest in the planting of economic crops and establish a capital fund for trading purposes and further capital expenditures.[33] While the African Industrial Society constituted collective action to counter discriminatory legislation, neither it nor its forerunner seem to have fitted the cooperative model.[34]

African Industrial Society members were in clear agreement over the major problems they faced as aspiring planters and traders even if they were less sure as to how they could be solved. Duncan Njilima chaired the first meeting of the organisation and, following opening prayers, led a freewheeling discussion in which key grievances and difficulties were isolated. Members pointed to the lack of thrift among Africans, the scarcity of labour, the need to create 'an independent native capital', the competition posed by Indian traders and the need to reduce dependence on them.[35] The African Industrial Society was unable to overcome such

---

the Nyasaland Planters' Association in 1903. The two organisations merged in 1907 to create the Associated Chamber of Agriculture and Commerce. Notes on the Nyasaland (MNA, NY3/2/1, Associated Chamber of Agriculture and Commerce.)

32 In August of 1909, the maximum number of members was raised from twenty to thirty persons and voting rights were upped from one shilling per vote per month to five shillings per vote per month. (MNA, S10/1/8/3, Minutes of the NIU, 14 August 1909.)

33 Booth, a peripatetic and theologically eclectic missionary, had considerable influence on the early life of John Chilembwe and it was with him that Chilembwe travelled to America at the turn of the century. For details on Booth's African Development Society plan see, Joseph Booth, *Africa for the African*, pamphlet (Baltimore, Maryland, 1897), pp. 39-41.

34 Bridglal Pachai described the African Industrial Society as a 'kind of African co-operative'. 'The Nyasaland Rising of 1915', Gordon W. Smith, Rodger Tangri and B. Pachai (eds.) *Malawi Past and Present*, Selected papers from the University of Malawi History Conference, 1967 (Blantyre, 1971), p. 120.

35 Shepperson and Price, *Independent African*, p. 167.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

enormous obstacles and two years later several of its members opted for direct action against the regime.

I have argued elsewhere that the 1915 rising resulted from a number of factors, but African *petit-bourgeois* participation was rooted in concrete economic and social grievances.[36] While wartime recruitment, the plight of Lomwe estate workers and the influence of Chilembwe were crucial factors in the rebellion, Chilembwe's 'officers' were drawn from the more affluent African planters and traders in Chiraduzulu.[37] After Chilembwe and his petit bourgeois cabal launched an assault on European planters in January of 1915, the Bismarcks, Bandawes and Mlangas rushed to disassociate themselves from the Njilimas, the Kufas and the Chilembwes.

In spite of its failure to bring about an 'Africa for the Africans' the Chilembwe uprising shook the foundations of white complacency in Nyasaland. Only eight out of twenty-six identifiable participants in meetings of the African Industrial Society were involved in the uprising, and they had close connections to John Chilembwe. Nevertheless, all African landholders in Chiradzulu district in 1915 participated and this fact did not elude the colonial administration.[38] Government recognized the need to bring 'progressive' Africans into the colonial fold, especially those who had travelled abroad and picked up dangerous ideas in the process. These individuals, according to one report,

> ... return [from U.S.A. and South Africa] to take up trading or planting, but the majority enter on religion and preaching as a business, the ease of the life and power and influence over their fellows appealing to them strongly ...[39]

There was some talk of involving educated Africans in local politics and providing them with economic security, all with an eye toward giving them a vested interest in the colonial system. In Governor Smith's view, a 'more individual property in the soil and vested interests in trade and industry' for Africans

---

36 Joey Power, 'Individual Enterprise and Enterprising Individuals: African Entrepreneurship in Blantyre and Limbe, 1907-1953', Dalhousie University Ph.D., 1991, Chapter Two.

37 In their landmark study of the Chilembwe uprising, Shepperson and Price point to *petit bourgeois* participation, but do not discuss the reasons for it. See, *Independent African*, pp. 242-253. See also, Rotberg, 'Psychological Stress'; Landeg White, *Magomero*; Bandawe, *Memoirs*; George Simeon Mwase, *Strike a Blow and Die, A Narrative of Race Relations in Colonial Africa by George Simeon Mwase*, edited and introduced by Robert Rotberg, (Cambridge, U.S., 1967); Mel Page, 'Malawians in the Great War and After, 1914-1925', Ph.D. Michigan State University, 1977; 'The War of *Thangata*: Nyasaland and the East African Campaign', *Journal of African History*, 14 (1978), pp. 87-100.

38 They were John Chilembwe (landowner), John Gray Kufa Mapantha (landowner and shop-keeper), Thomas Lulanga (land owner), Donald Malota (land owner), Duncan Njilima (land owner and shop-keeper), Hugh Mataka (land owner), and Whiskers Matengo (store owner, not listed as member of AIS). Comparison of names listed in Rotberg, 'Psychological Stress', Shepperson and Price, *Independent African*, Mwase, *Strike a Blow and Die*, Land Register, Blantyre, Volumes 1-3, cited in B. Pachai, *Land and Politics in Malawi, 1875-1975* (Kingston, 1978), pp. 50-51 and Government Notices 'Wanted Lists' for January and March, 1915. For Malota, see also, McCracken, '"Marginal Men"'.

39 PRO, CO525/78, Memorandum of 17 December 1917, initialled by Executive Council Member 'W.W.' sent to the Secretary of State.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

might 'go far in repressing predatory instincts and overt rebellious acts ...' He continued that 'there should be a gradual but extending participation by the more enlightened and progressive natives in their own administration' at the local level. Fearing an alliance between Ethiopianism and Islamic revivalism, Governor Smith wrote that the only way to combat the political 'guiding principles' present in each of these movements, was through secular education which would develop 'a higher sense of political and commercial development as opposed to religious concentration'.[40] Already, Smith and others recognised the political benefits which could accrue from providing the *petit bourgeoisie* with a sound economic base, foreshadowing part of the impulse behind cooperative development in the 1930s.

But, in 1916, the administration had neither funds, personnel nor political will to involve itself in African education or subsidize African plantation agriculture or trade. Instead, it purged the more radical Sectarian Missions and forged a political alliance with Muslim Yao chiefs.[41] As White has pointed out, they were the real beneficiaries of the Chilembwe uprising and from 1915 on, the state concentrated its efforts on strengthening the political and economic positions of these 'traditional' rulers.[42] The uprising and its aftermath lent new urgency to the search for sympathetic 'tribal authorities' and, at the same time, shifted the state attitude toward the educated elite from one of ambivalence to antipathy. It sewed the seeds of distrust of petit bourgeois Africans and marked the beginning of a tacit commitment to indirect rule in the south.[43]

At another level, administrative changes imposed after the rising were emblematic of a more general shift in colonial ideology and practice. Whereas before 1915, 'mission products' like Joseph Bismarck, Lewis Bandawe and even Mlelemba and Chilembwe were pointed to as living proof of the success of imperial tutelage,[44] the rebellion revealed individualization and 'detribalisation' as the problematic processes they were. By the 1930s, '[t]he notable confidence in the benefits of individualization ... was in the process of being replaced by a communalist caution, in response to a section of the population embracing economic individualism'.[45] 'Educating for progress' was abandoned in favour of a new imperial vision predicated upon the resurrection of a communal, egalitarian and largely mythical pre-colonial past.

---

40 PRO, CO525/78, Smith to Milne, 18 February 1918.

41 Shepperson and Price, *Independent African*, pp. 321-360.

42 White, '"Tribes"', pp. 511-541.

43 See also, Vail and White, 'Tribalism', pp. 168-9.

44 Missions were sentimentally connected to the eradication of the slave trade and the substitution for it of 'legitimate' commerce. Later, missions served the practical purpose of providing literate and skilled staff for firms and the administration. Fields, *Revival and Rebellion*, p. 48.

45 Chanock, 'A Peculiar Sharpness', p. 74.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Indirect Rule and the Cooperative Movement

The first step toward strengthening chiefly power in the south was the implementation of the District Administration (Native) Ordinance of 1912 which, after January 1915, gave government appointed principal and village headmen greater responsibilities in village affairs. They had limited judicial authority and had to work closely with the district resident, but gained greater power and influence than they would have in the absence of the ordinance.[46] The District Administration Natives Ordinance entrenched 'tribalism' as the dominant form of African politics in the south and so the 1920s witnessed 'a dramatic rise in the number of traditional authorities and ethnic identifications' in Southern Province.[47]

The traditional legitimacy of chiefs was highly suspect.[48] Tony Woods has shown that many designated headmen were of questionable pedigree, and were frequently chosen from estate capitaos.[49] In the Shire Highlands, chiefs and headmen soon began to overstep the bounds of the District Administration Natives Ordinance. They conducted court cases, imposed fines and exacted labour from their villagers.[50] Their ability to do so was expanded by their new role as tax collectors. Shire Highlands headmen were empowered to collect taxes as early as 1924. In addition to the direct benefits of tax collection, this gave them access to labour. The Lomwe continued to emigrate to the Highlands in large numbers during the 1920s and 1930s. In order for them to establish residency in Nyasaland, they had to have their tax paper signed by a chief. The *quid pro quo* for this was labour. Lomwe immigrants were only really compelled to work for chiefs their first year in Nyasaland. After this they could obtain a residence permit, which enabled them to migrate to other territories for better wages. Nevertheless, the more or less steady stream of Lomwe immigrants meant that by the 1930s tobacco produced by Lomwe immigrants on 'chiefly' lands, constituted 75 percent of the Protectorate's tobacco exports, positive proof that indirect rule was economically sound, at least from the bureaucratic perspective.[51] Moreover, chiefs did a fine job of recruiting labour for public works and functioned as a rudimentary 'spy network'. In sum, they were useful, if fractious, allies.

The uneasy alliance between 'traditional' authorities and the state was tested in the 1930s by rising levels of labour migration. Some twenty years earlier officials had linked the movement of 'Nyasas' to South Africa and beyond to political sedition. In the 1920s and 1930s, labour migration was held responsible for growing social and economic tensions at the village level. While chiefs were able

---

46 White, '"Tribes"', p. 527; Elias Mandala, *Work and Control in a Peasant Economy, A History of the Lower Tchiri Valley in Malawi, 1859-1960* (Madison, 1990), pp. 102-107.

47 Woods, 'Chiefs and Capitaos', p. 266.

48 Mandala makes a similar observation of the southern section of the Tchiri Valley. He argued that by sanctioning the headmanships of non-Mang'anja in Ruo and Lower Shire Districts, the state 'created the conditions for ethnic politics in the south.' Mandala, *Work and Control*, p. 103.

49 White, '"Tribes", pp. 526-527; Woods, 'Chiefs and Capitaos', pp. 266-267.

50 White, '"Tribes"', pp. 527, 528.

51 Ibid., pp. 530, 532-3; Vail and White, 'Tribalism', p. 171.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

to exploit the economic opportunities of cash cropping through manipulation of their new found status, labour migration meant a decline in their relative material wealth. It also posed a threat to chiefly authority in the form of lost villagers, tax revenues and prestige.

Labour migration was most common in the centre and north of the country, but by the 1930s, more and more southerners participated. Problems of maintaining local authority intensified in the 1930s as unemployed migrants, used to town life, were thrown back into village communities. After 1933, emigration levels began to rise again, and the question of regulating migration took on renewed urgency.[52] Northern chiefs complained that migration had 'lost its communal aspect' and it was suggested that, in the south as well, 'communal obligations [were] a diminishing force' underlying the exodus of young men. In other words, men were migrating for self-aggrandizement and not to support their village communities at home.[53] While the chiefs were concerned about how the system diminished their authority, social scientists and government officials despaired at the deleterious effects of labour migration, albeit for different reasons. The social scientists felt that migration caused family break down. Government was concerned about lost tax revenues represented by growing numbers of *machona* ('lost ones'), but also about how migrants acquired 'a complete mistrust in and loathing for administration by the white people which has made a wilderness and called it peace'.[54] To buttress chiefly authority and communal life, the state introduced formal indirect rule Protectorate wide in 1933-34. This, however, was only a partial remedy to the real and imagined problems associated with labour migration.[55]

As destructive of 'custom' (and the prestige of indirect rulers) as social scientists and officials believed it to be, labour migration was an important source of revenue for government. Returned migrants were consumers of imported goods and payers

---

[52] Nyasaland authorities could not get an accurate count of African emigrés because of the prevalence of uncovenanted migration, but the Native Commissioner for Southern Rhodesia did keep records of Nyasaland immigrants who negotiated contracts once in the country. In 1930 only 25,223 'Nyassas' were recorded at work in Southern Rhodesia. This fell to 11,426 in 1932 but had risen to 43,967 by 1934. Travers Lacey Report, p. 25.

[53] Officials also pointed to the immoral tendencies which migration engendered, stating that while few wives migrated with their husbands and while it was 'an exception for a Nyasaland husband to make money by prostituting his wife ... cases [did] occur'. (Ibid., pp. 44, 46.)

[54] MNA, COM8/1, *Report of the Commission to Enquire into Emigrant Labour, 1935* [hereafter, Travers Lacey Report], p. 92.

[55] The Native Authorities Courts Ordinance and the Native Authorities Treasuries Ordinance outlined the rights and responsibilities of Native Authorities or chiefs appointed to administer on the behalf of the Protectorate government. Headmen and chiefs drew salaries from Native Treasuries. Six pence in every tax payment was reserved for the treasury and monies collected from court fines and fees, market fees, beer and fishing permits were also paid into these pots. After 1936, Native Treasuries received 25% of all Native Trust Land leasehold rents collected in respect of plots falling within the Native Authority area. The remaining 75% of rents on Native Trust Land went to a Central Fund which was used to top up the Treasuries of those districts in a deficit position. (MNA, COM2/10, Bell Commission Report, 1937-8, No. 14, 'A Note on Native Administration', by J.C. Abraham, Senior Provincial Commissioner, 22 September 1937, pp. 4-9; MNA, NS1/21/10, Chief Secretary's circular, 18 March 1935.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

of taxes; so the system had long been defended as a necessary evil.[56] By the mid-thirties, the official consensus held that it was not migration itself which was destructive; rather, it was *unregulated* migration which was the problem. The Travers Lacey Report of 1935 recommended a return to government regulated recruiting, but emphasised that the long term solution to problems of labour migration would be economic, not administrative. In the short term, the trick was to ensure that migrants and a proportion of their earnings returned to the Protectorate. In the long run, however, government needed to foster viable economic alternatives at home.[57] Predictably, moral concerns took a back seat to economic imperatives during the depression years and in 1937 the Nyasaland and Rhodesian governments signed an agreement which permitted the Rhodesian Native Labour Association and others to reopen recruiting offices in Nyasaland. The Salisbury Agreement set out the terms and conditions under which labour migrants worked, travelled and were paid. Most importantly, the agreement stipulated that a portion of wages would be remitted home during the contract period and that taxes would be deducted at source.[58]

Cooperatives were first seriously discussed in the wake of the Travers Lacey Report and, to this extent, they were linked to the migrant labour issue.[59] While cooperatives were put forward as one of the alternatives to a labour reserve economy, they also dovetailed nicely with the political imperatives of indirect rule. Both 'models' were informed by a utopian, nineteenth century vision of African society. Officials firmly believed that, although under attack, communal and egalitarian value systems were tenacious and might be revived given the appropriate framework in which to thrive. Cooperatives might provide a useful forum for the advancement of its 'progressive' African community whose political future was still at issue.

---

[56] See for example, PRO, CO525/22, 'Report and suggestion relating to Nyasaland Natives at work in and proceeding to Southern Rhodesia', J.C. Casson, Superintendent for Native Affairs, 23 November 1907. Casson did not feel that migration in itself was bad; rather it required regulation and control.

[57] Travers Lacey Report, pp. 44, 46.

[58] The Salisbury Agreement was signed by representatives of Northern and Southern Rhodesia and Nyasaland in 1937. It received sanction of the Colonial Secretary in June of that year. In July, an inter-territorial Standing Committee on Migrant Labour was struck to oversee implementation of the agreement which came into effect on 1 March 1938. For details of agreement see, MNA, LB1/4/1, F1, Memorandum of proceedings at a conference on the Labour Agreement held at Salisbury on 7th, 8th, and 9th July 1937; and MNA, LB1/4/1/, F3 for another meeting on the 3rd and 4th December 1937.

[59] A kind of cooperative had been suggested for an urban organisation several years before. The Ndirande Welfare Centre opened in August 1933 and was to function as a weekly clinic for women and infants. This joint African Church of Scotland Mission effort was followed up in September with the formation of the Ndirande Welfare Club — an athletic and social club for educated clerks, civil servants and their families. In the following year, the Provincial Commissioner Southern Province J.C. Abraham minuted of the Ndirande Welfare Club 'This enterprise contains the nucleus of a cooperative society for wider purposes'. He did not elaborate on these 'wider purposes'. (MNA, NSB7/1/3, F126, Blantyre District Annual Report 1933, G.F. Phillip; and MNA, S1/247.H/34, Senior Provincial Commissioner Abrahams marginal note, Annual Report Blantyre and Neno Districts 1933, p. 8.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

The African *petit bourgeoisie* played a marginal role in the indirect rule system. For this reason, Native Associations were formed to provide a mechanism through which to lobby government. While essentially conservative, these associations attempted to carve out a political niche for *petit-bourgeois* Africans. Their interests differed from and were frequently at odds with those of the 'traditional' rulers. The Southern Province Native Association, founded in 1923, was the first of these in the south.[60] The Association did not deny the legitimacy of chiefly interest, but saw the 'educated' elite as constituting a distinct lobby group. In 1931, it protested against the ruling that its petitions would have to go through the District Council of chiefs, preferring direct lines of communication with government.[61] Government signified through the expansion of the indirect rule apparatus that, over and above an advisory role, the political role of 'progressive' Africans was to remain subordinate to chiefs and headmen.

The economic role of the African *petit bourgeoisie* was also poorly articulated and understood by the state. By the early 1920s it was clear that there many white collar and self-employed Africans who earned yearly incomes in excess of £50.[62] An African income tax was debated in 1925, but was discarded when it promised to be too costly to administer.[63] The Nyasaland administration wanted to harness this income, but also to guide the economic development of the 'progressive' African classes, since 'experience in other countries, including West Africa, teaches that individual as opposed to collective trading creates a class of men divorced from tribal influences, who become produce brokers and money lenders extending cash on the security of crops'.[64] Cooperatives, like indirect rule structures, would flourish in Nyasaland since they emphasized corporate spirit and group effort, values and methods which they believed (or hoped) were still firmly rooted in the African psyche. They simply required an appropriate structure to bring them out. Indirect rule would recreate 'traditional' authority patterns, and cooperatives would provide an appropriate mechanism for corporate economic 'progress'.

There were African voices among the mission educated elite which seemed to support the 'merrie Afrika' myth of colonial rhetoric. Levi Mumba, for example, articulated an 'anti-individualist' message:

> The European came with his individualism and thrust it on the native. If there is any one thing, more that all others which has changed and spoiled a primitive people

---

[60] The Southern Province Native Association's first secretary was Frederick Gresham *alias* Frederick Njilima, son of Duncan Njilima, one of Chilembwe's 'lieutenants' hanged after the 1915 rising. McCracken, '"Marginal Men"', pp. 551-560.

[61] Chanock, 'Ambiguities', p. 331.

[62] PRO, CO525/108, Bowring to Secretary of State J.H. Thomas, 23 July 1924.

[63] PRO CO525/111, 'Report of a Committee to enquire into Native Taxation', 10 June 1925, p. 9.

[64] MNA, S1/185/39, F 2-4, Bingham, Memo on Cooperative Consumer Societies, 29 May 1939.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

> with no education for guidance, it is this individualism. I hate individualism, because it has suddenly torn the son from the father, or one man from another.[65]

Mumba's critique of individualism, Chanock has noted, did not extend to his thoughts on business enterprises, but this escaped policy-makers.[66] So, it seems, did the magnitude and significance of class differentiation within the Protectorate's African population. Government merely noted the existence of 'educated' Africans, self-employed tradespeople, labour migrants of various different levels of skill, village farmers and newly constituted Native Authorities. It did not seem to recognize the extent to which these groups' interests diverged and their actions were rooted in new group and individual consciousnesses.

This was no better exemplified than in the state's efforts to 'educate' its indirect rulers to their assigned roles. Rhetoric notwithstanding, there was little that was traditional or evolutionary about indirect rule.[67] When policy failed to be translated into practice (when Native Authorities overstepped their assigned bounds), the state intervened in the belief that this was the result of miscommunication and little more. With this in mind, the state set about an ambitious project of social engineering which it hoped would smooth out the rough spots in indirect rule.

In 1934, a training programme for chiefs was begun at the Jeanes Training Centre at Domasi. Provincial Commissioner Leslie explained the necessity for training in his welcoming speeches to incoming Native Authorities:

> ... government knows that it is not easy to be a chief and so the government wishes to help the chiefs as much as it can to learn about new ways to aid their people to progress; to understand the reasons for changing old ways; and so to fit them for the task they must do as chiefs. This task is to be the leaders of their people.[68]

Chiefly instruction emphasized collective responsibility and self-help. Chiefs received lessons in civics, arithmetic and book-keeping, hygiene and sanitation and, significantly, historical geography. They were also taught simple economics related to raw materials and local manufactures and how Nyasaland fitted into the imperial

---

65 L. Mumba, 'Memorandum on the Administration of Justice in Nyasaland', undated but Chanock puts it at 1925, cited in Chanock, 'Ambiguities', p. 335.

66 Ibid., Chanock notes this in fn. 28 and refers to his research on Mumba in 'The New Men Revisited. An essay on the Development of Political Consciousness in Colonial Malawi', R.J. MacDonald (ed.), *From Nyasaland to Malawi, Studies in Colonial History* (Nairobi, 1975), p. 251.

67 Lugard noted that the 'task of the administrative officer is to clothe his principles in the garb of evolution, not of revolution ...' (*The Dual Mandate*, p. 194).

68 MNA, NS1/8/4, Provincial Commissioner Southern Province, 'The Importance of Understanding', chapter for a book to be used in talks to chiefs at Jeanes Training Centre, n.d. The chiefs' programme ran from April 1934 to 1949. (See Barbara Morrow, '"... it is not easy to be a chief": Training for Native Authorities in the 1930s in Nyasaland — Colonial Ideals and Grass-roots Realities', Chancellor College History Department Seminar Paper No. 2, 1986.) It is perhaps no surprise that the Jeanes slogan was 'Better, happier and healthier citizens, and cooperation for social improvement'. (Memo, Director of Education to Provincial and District Commissioners, January 1935, cited in Megan Vaughan, '"Better, Happier and Healthier Citizens": the Domasi Community Development Scheme, 1949-54', Chancellor College History Department Seminar Paper No. 4, 1983, p. 1.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

scheme. All this was designed to create efficient bureaucrats, but as Barbara Morrow has shown, trainees had their own ideas about 'what it meant to be a chief'. While the authorities aimed to create better administrators through training in literacy and numeracy, chiefs were more interested in political power. In the 1930s, for example, both Tumbuka and Ngoni paramounts embarked upon imperial projects of their own by invading neighbouring territories.[69] Only two years after attending the first 'chiefs' course' at Domasi, Native Authority Chikulumaembe suggested a parliament of chiefs which would assist in the formation of policy.[70] Chiefs clearly differed from colonial officials in their conception of what indirect rule should be.

While chiefs were to be taught how to be chiefly, the 'progressive' African was to be taught thrift, prudence and honesty through cooperation. Significantly, the first forum for discussion was the Nyasaland Protectorate Native Welfare Committee. The Committee was formed in 1936 to oversee 'development' projects and its financial base was derived from the capitation fees paid out by employers of labour and labour recruiters.[71] Because officials reckoned that 'tribal authority' in the protectorate was weak (one of the reasons for giving indirect rule a 'shot in the arm' in the early 1930s), participation in cooperative endeavours would be strictly voluntary.

In these early days, officials had only a vague notion of what shape the cooperative movement would take in Nyasaland, but documentation suggests that they hoped it would focus on the production and distribution of economic crops. The chairman of the Native Welfare Committee expressed as much when he said that cooperative marketing would probably be more useful in Nyasaland than credit societies.[72] The assumption was that cooperatives would have a rural focus. Men like Governor Kittermaster had little doubt that were cooperatives a sound idea, only slight encouragement would be needed to garner the support of Nyasaland's Africans who were 'unusually intelligent especially where making money is concerned'. Kittermaster reckoned that 'if a profit [could] be shown ... natives [would] accept the scheme'.[73] What Kittermaster and others did not understand was the extent to which the taint of state involvement would discourage African participation.

---

69 Vail and White, 'Tribalism', pp. 159, 163.

70 Morrow, '"...it is not easy to be a chief"', p. 3.

71 It was the Travers Lacey Report which recommended that labour recruiters and employers should pay a capitation fee, or a levy on each worker hired or recruited. This money should then be put in a fund which would be used for the betterment of Africans generally. This was first done in April of 1937 when the Tanganyika Forests and Lumber Company was levied a £1 fee for each recruit. After January 1938, Southern Rhodesian recruiters were assessed a 10 shilling fee per worker and after February 1939, all recruiters were assessed. The Witwatersrand Native Labour Association was charged a lower fee of only six pence per head in return for a guarantee that it would shoulder the expense of travel and food for workers *en route* to and from the south. (MNA, LB1/4/2, F1, Eric Smith, Memorandum on Migrant Labour, n.d.)

72 MNA, S1/1566II/26, F 17-18, A.D.J.B. Williams to Chief Secretary, 9 October 1936.

73 Ibid., F3, Kittermaster to J.H. Thomas, 7 May 1936.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

In an effort to gather more information, Kittermaster petitioned the Colonial Office in July of 1936. He asked that they send out a cooperative expert. The Colonial Office suggested that the Nyasaland government send one of its own administrative officers for three to four months training in Ceylon, where interesting work on cooperatives was already taking place. This would give their operative 'hands on' experience and spare the Colonial Office the £2,000 required to train him in Nyasaland. The trip would be funded by the Carnegie Foundation, an American philanthropic organisation with close ties to the Jeanes schools.[74]

The Welfare Committee's man, District Commissioner H.F. Bingham, conducted a seven month fact-finding mission to Europe, West Africa and Ceylon, from which he returned in March 1938.[75] He delivered an enthusiastic report to the Native Welfare Committee in which he outlined a cooperative plan for Nyasaland.[76] The cooperative movement was to begin with the establishment of credit societies to 'instil the idea of thrift among the people' and provide 'a foundation of business knowledge'. It would also foster 'the creation of the cooperative spirit where everyone works for one common interest'.[77]

It was at this point that the administration made a colossal miscalculation. Instead of 'communal tribesmen', the initial target group of cooperators for thrift and loan societies would be drawn from educated 'detribalized' Africans.[78] Bingham's colleagues were sceptical. The main attraction of cooperatives was the potential revenue benefits accruing from economic crop production.[79] The mission elite were least likely to be useful in this regard. Moreover, was not one of the strongest arguments for viable cooperatives their compatibility with 'traditional' African society? Why should cooperatives start with ventures like thrift and loan societies, especially those focused around African entrepreneurs and white collar workers whose orientation was increasingly individualistic?

Bingham insisted on beginning with the educated elite for two reasons — one was practical, the other political. He contended that illiteracy and lack of business knowledge were the main stumbling blocks for cooperative development. Hence, educated Africans had the requisite skills to make a go of it. Educated Africans were

---

74 Ibid., F10-13, Ormsby-Gore to Kittermaster 23 July 1936.

75 Ibid., F17-18, A.D.J.B. Williams, Chairman of the Native Welfare Committee to Chief Secretary, 9 October 1936; ibid., F15, Minutes of 12th Meeting of the Native Welfare Committee, 2 September 1936.

76 MNA, NS1/3/6, F50-89, Report on a Tour undertaken to Study Cooperatives in Europe, West Africa and Ceylon. H.F. Bingham, 14 May 1938. From 15 September to 11 October, Bingham visited Czechoslovakia, Hungary, Jugoslavia and the Baltic. From 20 October to 23 December, he visited Nigeria (mostly the major towns) and Gold Coast. He was in Ceylon from January 15 to March 1938.

77 MNA, M2/3/10, F13, Minutes of A Special Meeting of the Native Welfare Committee, 11 April 1938.

78 Morrow has pointed out that educated chiefs were the preferred candidates for the chiefs' school at Jeanes. (Morrow, '"... it is not easy to be a chief"', p. 2.)

79 The Native Welfare Committee discussed this at some length since members believed that cooperatives had an important role to play in production. Already enterprises were established which might have been turned into cooperatives, for example, ghee production at Mzimba and rice at Nkhota Kota. (MNA, M2/3/10, F13b, Minutes of A Special Meeting of the Native Welfare Committee, 11 April 1938.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

more or less concentrated in the administrative and economic centres which would ease supervision. Moreover, 'thrift and loan' societies were a crucial first step in establishing a financial base for further cooperative ventures. Marketing and producer cooperatives, he argued, were the 'ultimate development of cooperation', for which the average Nyasaland tribesman of 1938 was unprepared.[80]

Second, the educated elite would benefit from credit societies 'morally' as well as materially. The spectre of Chilembwe reared its fearful head in the 1930s. To wit, cooperatives might serve to forestall the emergence of unsavoury political and economic tendencies among this group:

> ... if a handful of educated Africans can get command in the economic sphere without proper guidance, they will develop on individualist and capitalist lines (in imitation of the European) and will grow out of sympathy with the troubles and difficulties of their own people.[81]

Hence, the cooperative impulse could launch a pre-emptive strike against the emergence of pernicious individualism and capitalism. These tendencies had to be ferreted out for the greater political and economic good. The cooperative model would divert the ambitious African capitalist from his anti-social path. An individualistic, economically empowered and politicised African class had no place within the indirect rule system. Individualism was, after all, the 'antithesis of indirect rule'.[82]

Bingham added that educated Africans were keen on the project. A preliminary survey conducted in May 1938 revealed a 'general admission of indebtedness' among white collar Africans. He also cited two cases where lack of capital and credit hampered artisans in their attempts to start up business. The first was a carpenter who, having no money with which to buy his own tools, went to South Africa to earn money to buy them. The second was a brickmaker who was forced to abandon a contract for lack of funds to pay his workers.[83] Thrift and loan societies could do much to help such people.

Just as Megan Vaughan discovered in her study of community development projects at the Jeanes Centre, it was the educated elite who found 'modern' schemes most appealing, but not always for the reasons the authorities hoped. Bingham was convinced that cooperatives were good and, if they were explained carefully, their adoption would be automatic. As with community development and chiefs' programmes, communication was considered to be the key. This blinkered view, rooted in a fundamental paternalism, denied the autonomous decision-making power of incipient 'cooperators'. It further revealed the manifest confusion of colonial authorities over the role of the individual in communal projects. The ideals of community development and cooperatives assumed the paramountcy of corporate

---

80 Ibid., F13a.

81 MNA, NS1/3/6, F111-123, Annual Report, Cooperative Movement, H.F. Bingham, 25 January 1939.

82 MNA, NS1/3/12, F97, Minute: Chief Secretary Ken Hall, 11 July 1931.

83 MNA, NS1/3/6, F.47-49, Cooperation Interim Report, 23 May 1938 by H.F. Bingham.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

interests over those of the individual, but the success of such schemes rested upon the combined efforts of individuals. This was more than an academic point, since the enthusiasm of scheme followers was self-interested. In Vaughan's words:

> ... the community development enthusiasts who sat around in conferences in Britain and advised the Colonial Office, professed to see 'individualism' as a creeping danger to African societies, but in Domasi it became clear that those who responded to the innovations and requirements of the scheme were precisely those people who showed the clearest signs of individualism, in the Western sense. Not surprisingly, 'self-help' appealed to those with education and skills, frequently those employed by the scheme itself or by the Jeanes Training Centre, and often those from outside the district.[84]

The role of the ambitious individuals in cooperative ventures posed the same dilemma. However, Bingham believed that these people should be involved in the cooperative project and that the experience would bring out their cooperative spirit and save them from the evils of capitalism. He could not have been more incorrect.

By January 1939, there were three 'thrift and loan' societies in Southern Province and by May, there were others in Lilongwe, Kasungu, Mzimba, Dowa and Nkhota Kota.[85] They were dismal failures. The Mzimba, Nkhota Kota and Dedza societies were wound up within a year.[86] Others struggled on after a fashion but had collapsed by 1942-43.[87] Among them were the Blantyre Native Civil Servants Thrift and Loan and the Blantyre Commercial Clerks Thrift and Loan. As at February 1943, the latter had a membership of fourteen, £47.17.5 on account and £29.19.4 in loans outstanding.[88]

The long term objective of such societies was to provide a source of capital for investment in consumer and producer cooperatives. But members were impatient. Cooperative meeting minutes reveal the chronic problem of bad debts and members who failed to keep up their subscriptions.[89] Members ceased contributions when they received little immediate benefit from the societies. They favoured the idea of a consumers' cooperative — something which would give immediate returns in the form of lower prices for consumer goods. The Blantyre Commercial Clerks Thrift and Loan, for example, attempted to function as a consumer society in 1941 when its Vice President received authorization to buy three tons of maize for resale to

[84] Vaughan, '"Better, Happier and Healthier Citizens"', p. 15.

[85] The Native Civil Servants (Blantyre) Thrift and Loan, the Zomba Cooperative Thrift and Loan and the Commercial Clerks (Blantyre) Thrift and Loan. The Native Civil Servants (Blantyre) Cooperative was formed on 30 June 1938 and the other two on 1 October 1938. Original memberships stood at fifteen, twelve and fifteen respectively. (MNA, S11/1/2/4, F23d, Minute, Bingham, 24 June 1939.)

[86] Ibid., F69, Bingham to Chief Secretary, 27 August 1940.

[87] MNA, NSB3/3/6, F13, District Commissioner R.H. Garvey to Provincial Commissioner Southern Province, 3 February 1943,

[88] Ibid., F12, Garvey to Provincial Commissioner Southern Province, 3 February 1943.

[89] MNA, NA1/1/1, Blantyre Native Civil Servants Thrift and Loan Society Minute Book, 20 May 1938 to 7 May 1941.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

members at reduced prices.[90] But this was an isolated incident and members lost interest in the project.

In order to salvage the movement, Bingham decided to force the pace and conceded that other types of cooperative ventures might be tried. In a 1939 memorandum he reiterated the benefits of cooperation for raising general prosperity rather than enriching a few, and added, significantly, that cooperative trading 'provides a direct and comprehensible outlet for the Native's surplus capital'. He pointed to the increase in postal money orders paid out in Northern Province especially and lamented that, in many districts, these funds were invested in cattle. Trading cooperatives might provide an attractive alternative to what was, in his mind, 'unproductive' investment. Again he stressed the value of cooperatives to counteract the 'evils inherent in individual Native Trading'.[91]

In 1939, a consumers' cooperative store was set up at the Jeanes Centre at Domasi in Zomba District. In August 1939, another one was proposed for Blantyre Mission, where several enthusiasts had already begun to pool resources for the scheme.[92] A training programme for cooperators was set up at the Jeanes Training Centre in Domasi, the same venue for the training of indirect rulers. There 'cooperators-in-training' attended lectures on the theory of cooperative development and the relationship of cooperative stores to the movement as a whole. People were told that consumer cooperatives were to be totally self-reliant. They must raise their own capital through subscriptions and investments. All transactions would be on a cash basis and credit could be extended only in very special circumstances.[93]

Jeanes trainees went away and adapted what they had learned to suit their own objectives. Blantyre District Commissioner Ion Ramsay reported a 'definite indication in several areas, of movements with the object of forming African trading syndicates'. The impetus for these came from several Jeanes trainees.[94] It was not the egalitarian, profit sharing message which attracted Jeanes graduates. Rather, they were attracted by the notion of pooling resources to further individual business aims. Cooperation had become little more than a smoke-screen for private trading.

Since the 1910s entrepreneurs had demonstrated an interest in limited companies, but government declined to assist such ventures.[95] On the contrary, the formation of syndicates like the Ndirande Trading Company at Nsoni was discouraged. The

---

[90] Ibid., Ngolleka bought the maize from Henry Ascroft, a coloured transporter and produce dealer. Blantyre Native Civil Servants Thrift and Loan Society Minute Book, 7 May 1941.

[91] MNA, S1/185/39, F2-4, Memorandum on Cooperative Consumers' Societies, 29 May 1939.

[92] Ibid., Minute: G.H. Adams, Financial Secretary, 15 August 1939; and Minute: Chief Secretary Hall, 17 August 1939.

[93] Ibid., F2-4, Memorandum on Cooperative Consumers' Societies, 29 May 1939.

[94] MNA, NSB7/1/5, Annual Report Blantyre District 1939, p. 7.

[95] Not all officials shared this sentiment. In April of 1939, Ion Ramsay, District Commissioner for Blantyre, was approached by two representatives of a new syndicate for a trading licence. The shop was at Matowa, 10 miles south of Blantyre township and 2 miles from the nearest non-African shops. He suggested that if they qualified as a cooperative, they would not need to pay licence fees. When Ramsay asked Bingham for advice on the matter, Bingham replied that the men were in no way eligible for assistance and a retail licence was indeed required. (MNA, NSB7/1/5, Annual Report Blantyre District 1939, p. 8.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Ndirande Trading Company was formed in 1938. It had ten shareholders, some of whom were descendants of African Industrial Society members. Like those men, they also shared the common experience of mission education, white collar employment and so on. Jason Kachale, brother of one of the founders, could recall nine of the ten investors in the Ndirande Trading Company. They were: John Kachale (a Town Council clerk), Samuel Nankhuni (a teacher), Sidney Somanje (a teacher at Henry Henderson Institute), Willie Gray Kufa (an African landowner and descendant of John Gray Kufa Mpantha), Norman Mambelela (a printer at Blantyre Mission), William Bruce Matenje (a teacher at Blantyre Mission), Reverend J.D. Sangaya, William Harrison Pembereka, and Grant Kamlangira.[96] The Ndirande Trading Company's main function was sawyering and the sale of pre-made clothing. It was located on Willie Gray Kufa's estate at Nsoni, formerly owned by John Gray Kufa and the site of P.T.K. Industries.

Bingham predicted that the company would probably not fly, but even if it did such an entity ran counter to the greater good of the Protectorate's African population and should probably be discouraged. In his words,

> There is a decided tendency among educated natives to copy the purely capitalist methods of Europeans. Every man who can command a small capital wishes to plunge into business. With lack of capital and above all lack of business experience this is likely to lead to disaster. The Ndirande Trading Company, recently registered, is an example. It is probably undesirable to stand by and watch the creation of a capitalist class rather than to encourage development on communal lines. I have thought it worth while to mention this tendency for cooperation can do much to act as a brake upon purely selfish effort and may help to educate more advanced natives in their responsibilities towards their more backward brothers.[97]

Around the time that he wrote this memorandum, Bingham approached the Ndirande Trading Company members with the suggestion that the syndicate might be transformed into a cooperative. Jason Kachale said that government officials tried to convince the Ndirande Trading Company owners that a cooperative structure would be better for them, but they resisted this:

> It wasn't a cooperative, but the government was advising these people to make a cooperative, but they say they preferred a trading company. And they [the government?] said that it was difficult, because you know, to run a company of that nature ... The government was ... doing something ... encouraging people to create cooperatives. But these people did not involve themselves in cooperatives.[98]

---

[96] Interview 39 Jason Gray Kachale, Ndirande, Blantyre District, 13 June 1988. MNA, NSB3/3/5, F9, Sangala to District Commissioner, 5 August 1941. Confirmed by Interview 31, Mokrin Sangala, Ndirande, Blantyre District, 7 May 1987.

[97] MNA, NS1/3/6, F97-100, Bingham to Abraham, 3 September 1938.

[98] Interview 39 Jason Gray Kachale.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

According to Kachale, the Ndirande Trading Company members resisted cooperation because they feared this would result in a government takeover. The Lirangwe Limemakers (based 30 miles north of Blantyre), who Bingham had tried to 'cooperatise' around the same time, expressed similar reservations. Evans Zintambira, a prominent lime maker and transporter in the 1940s and 1950s, confirmed that Bingham often visited Lirangwe, but that he and his fellow lime makers resisted cooperation, fearing 'that if we made a society, the whites would take over our business'.[99] These stories speak volumes about the ingrained distrust with which Africans greeted government initiatives *vis à vis* African enterprise by the 1930s and the determination with which they blocked official involvement in them.

The Ndirande Trading Company dissolved in 1946 because of 'misunderstandings' between members.[100] Kachale did not supply details of the break up, but implied that the company failed from lack of small 'c' cooperation. In Kachale's view, the way to avoid disagreement was to do business on one's own; too many cooks spoiled the broth. When asked to compare the Ndirande Trading Company with the business of a prominent Ndirande grocer, Mr. Kachale volunteered that he thought Mr. P. 'was better because he was doing by himself, by his own personal courage and efforts'.[101] The view that a single proprietorship was better than partnership or collective business organisation was very common. Research into capitalist business in Southern Province revealed this to be a common sentiment. Entrepreneurs hesitated to participate in joint ventures because of the sacrifice in autonomous decision-making that this frequently involved. Cooperatives which emerged in Southern Province during the 1940s and 1950s were often a cover for syndicates and companies which met the needs of individual businessmen.

Most cooperatives in the Southern Province which functioned in the period up to 1945 did so marginally or not strictly speaking as cooperatives. The Matowa Cooperative and Lauderdale African Coop in Mlanje District resembled companies more than cooperatives. For example, membership in each was closed.[102] When W.K.H. Campbell, a cooperative 'expert' from Nairobi, toured the Protectorate in 1945, he confirmed this impression. He found that the Nkhotakota Rice Scheme was running like a limited company with 400 shareholders and the majority of the

---

[99] Interview 19 Nelson Evans Zintambira, Lirangwe, T.A. Chigaru, Blantyre District, 6 March 1987.

[100] Mr Kachale was hesitant to give details surrounding the dissolution of the NTC, but implied that personality conflicts were at the root of it. As at December 31, 1946, the NTC had an unclaimed balance of £61.10.4 in its Barclay's Bank account. The account's penultimate transaction was dated September 25, 1944. (GN41/47, 31 January 1947.)

[101] Interview 39 Jason Gray Kachale.

[102] MNA, S11/2/5, F12, District Commissioner for Mlanje Rangeley to Bingham, 27 July 1944. The Lauderdale African Cooperative was formed by Joseph Chingwalu, a Clerk-typist who worked on the Mini Mini Tea Estate. The society had 38 members whose aim was to contribute £10 each. By July 1944, they had managed to collect £52.18.0. Rangeley remarked that these Africans had formed more of a company than a cooperative, and that the 'leaders are among the better and more progressive class of African and their effort at cooperation is probably worth direction into better channels and encouragement'.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

4,000 people actually producing rice did not share in the profits. He found similar developments at two ghee production centres at Zomba and Chitara. Ghee producers were:

> merely capitalists who have had the enterprise and business acumen to purchase separators and churns and erect the simple buildings required. They are usually school-masters, butchers etc., with no other interest in the ghee industry, and they appear to be battening on it to the detriment of the actual milk producers.[103]

Campbell was concerned to pre-empt the further development of such inequitable arrangements and he believed, like Bingham, that cooperatives might do much to ameliorate the situation. Pursuant to this, a permanent Cooperative Division was created in 1946. Bingham became its first Registrar the following year.[104] The cooperative programme was broadened to include producer and marketing cooperatives, but these initiatives did little to enhance cooperative popularity in the south.

The last effort to form a cooperative in Southern Province was initiated by a court clerk, James Frederick Sangala. Sangala, a Yao from Zomba District, was a mission-educated individual of considerable drive and vision. He was a respected member of Blantyre's African community and Chairman of the Ndirande Welfare Club, and he helped to found the Nyasaland African Congress in 1944. He had a long and respectable employment record in both public and private sectors and his cooperative vision included strong political elements.[105]

In September 1943 Sangala had already begun to organize Blantyre Africans to form a Nyasaland African Company which was to serve as a mouthpiece for African interests.[106] This company or 'Nyasaland African Association' would concern itself with general Protectorate matters and 'cooperate with the Government, Commercial, Planter and Missionary bodies and the Native Authorities in any matters necessary to speed up the progress of Nyasaland'.[107] Its mandate echoed much of the rhetoric of Bismarck's Native Industrial Union of 30 years before, and it had a strong economic component. The Nyasaland African Congress was formed a year later. It became the political mouthpiece of African grievances protectorate-wide and had no economic arm (although many of its

---

[103] MNA, S11/1/2/2, W.K.H. Campbell, Cooperative Adviser, 'Report on a visit to Nyasaland', 1 September 1945.

[104] *The Cooperative Societies Ordinance*, No. 20 of 1946, 31 August 1946; MNA, Ministry of Trade and Industry, Coop Division, File No. 14019, F20a, Annual Report of Registrar of Cooperative Societies, 1947, March 1948.

[105] MNA, NSB3/3/5, F9, Minutes of General Meeting, Ndirande Welfare Club, 15 June 1941; MNA, SA/1/1/1, 'A Brief History of James Frederick Sangala s/o Sangala', District Commissioner Dedza, June 1949 (autobiography) and Interview No.31, Mokrin Sangala s/o J.F. Sangala, Ndirande, Blantyre District, 7 May 1987.

[106] MNA, NSB3/3/6, F1, Sangala to Senior Provincial Commissioner, 3 September 1943. The letter was published in the *Nyasaland Times* (Blantyre), *Bantu Mirror* (Bulawayo), and *Nkhani za Nyasaland* (the government approved vernacular paper of the day). (Ibid., F2, 1 October 1943.)

[107] *Nyasaland Times*, 25 October 1943.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

members were independent business people). Nevertheless, Sangala had not abandoned the principle of economic self-reliance.

In July 1947 Sangala managed to organize a meeting of several Native Authorities and interested African retail traders in Blantyre to discuss the establishment of a wholesale cooperative store. It was to be owned and managed by Africans. The objective was to reduce the reliance on European and Indian wholesalers who, during the depression and the war, had been able to control retail trade.[108] Here was an African solution to a grievance articulated by Duncan Njilima and others as far back as 1913. White collar African employees from Blantyre, several independent entrepreneurs and traders from as far afield as Chiradzulu, Lirangwe, Chileka, Luchenza and Mpemba rallied to the call.[109]

Bingham attended the preliminary meeting for the cooperative and, after listening to the discussion, expressed serious reservations about the project. His criticisms reveal the divergence of interests between the authorities and African traders. First, Bingham reminded those attending that the basic unit of a cooperative movement was the 'primary' society — in a consumers' cooperative structure, this would be the retail cooperative store with local membership. Chiradzulu and Luchenza, for example, were too far apart for members to be able to benefit from such a store. It was only through the association of a number of successful 'primary' (retail) societies that a 'secondary' (wholesale) society might be formed.[110] He supplied a graphic representation of the organisation:

	Primary D	
Primary A		Primary E
Primary B	COOPERATIVE	Primary F
	WHOLESALE	
	SOCIETY	
	(Secondary Society)	
Primary C		Primary G
	Primary H	

Secondly, 'no single person' or firm should constitute a Primary Society, since then 'individuals could buy at wholesale prices for retail in their own private stores'. And it was not the objective of cooperatives to provide individual retailers with wholesale goods. Cooperative societies were designed to benefit consumers

[108] Because of import quotas during the war, wholesalers became more selective in their retail clients and began opening retail outlets themselves. During the depression years, wholesalers were able to capitalise on retail bankruptcies by speculating in trading plot leases. After the war, when it became easier to obtain retail trade licenses, these wholesalers had acquired the best trading sites and either set up their own agents on them or rented the plots to independents at exorbitant rates. See, Power, 'Individual Enterprise', Chapter Three.

[109] MNA, NSB3/3/6, F19, Sangala to Bingham, 15 July 1947.

[110] Ibid., F20, Bingham to Sangala, 17 July 1947.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

through economies of scale and were not for the benefit of private retailers. The point was to keep consumer prices low through bulk buying or to keep them at market level and periodically redistribute profits according to use. Bingham wrote to Sangala:

> I suspect, and I hope I am wrong, that numbers of individual traders hope to obtain supplies of goods at wholesale prices for resale in their own private stores. This, of course, would be utterly wrong. The function of a Wholesale Society is to supply goods to Co-operative Retail Societies and not to individuals.[111]

Bingham's suspicion was, of course, correct. African traders wanted a government assisted African cooperative which could supply them with goods at wholesale prices for their private businesses. Why should they sacrifice their right to set prices to a cooperative venture, especially in a climate of intense competition? When it became clear that a cooperative would limit their autonomy, African traders withdrew their support.

Instead of the desired wholesale cooperative, a consumer cooperative, Mvano Stores, was established in Blantyre town at the end of 1947. Its membership consisted mainly of government and private clerical workers. It dealt in cotton piece goods and local commodities.[112] Mvano did not survive. Its failure can be attributed not to managerial incompetence, but to the inadequacy of the cooperative model in the context of protectorate trade in the post war period. By virtue of its charter, the cooperative was compelled to insist on cash purchases only. Since credit buying was 'freely offered by Indian storekeepers,' Bingham doubted whether 'members [would] have the strength of character to forgo the privilege ... and purchase for cash at their own store'.[113] And he was right. In Blantyre town, wage earners relied, to a large extent, on credit purchases at month end to tide them over until the next pay packet. African and Indian sellers recognized this and acted accordingly.[114] Extending credit to consumers attracted a clientele and ensured future custom. Mvano could not compete with this.

By 1948 there were other options if people wished to 'buy African'. Ndirande and Chichiri, two of Blantyre-Limbe's peri-urban villages, already had several large groceries and dry goods shops owned and run by Africans.[115] There were no Indian

---

[111] Ibid.

[112] Ibid., F21, Sangala's circular to *Nyasaland Times*, *3ntu Mirror*, and *African Weekly*, n.d., copy to Registrar of Cooperatives, received 11 August 1947. The society was registered in mid-December with a membership of twenty-four and a share capital of £65. (Ibid., F25, Minutes of the First General Meeting of the Blantyre Mvano Store Limited, 13 December 1947.)

[113] MNA, Ministry of Trade and Industry, Cooperative Division, 14019, F20a, Annual Report for Cooperatives, 1947, March 1948.

[114] Many people freely attested to the practise of credit buying. Interview 10, Ruth Ascroft, Chirimba, Blantyre District, 4 February 1987; Interview 22, Edward Damba, Blantyre, Blantyre District, 14 March 1987; Interview 27 Moses Takomana, Blantyre, Blantyre District, 18 March 1987; Interview 48 Wilfred Kampadzaza, Kampadzaza Village, T.A. Machinjiri, Blantyre District, 23 June 1988.

[115] In the Blantyre-Limbe peri-urban area, the two biggest shops were owned by B.F. Chinseu and Steven Phambana, and there were numerous other small stores and canteens. Interview 37,

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

or European shops in these areas and African grocers commonly sold on a credit basis. They also offered other attractions to consumers. They were situated immediately in the peri-urban areas where most of Blantyre-Limbe's African population lived, conveniently located for 'last minute' purchases of soap, salt and other essential items. Finally, African grocers were more willing than their non-African counterparts to sell in small quantities. Small portion selling was another inducement for consumers on tight budgets who were not able to purchase in large quantities at lean times of the month.

Mvano Stores, on the other hand, was situated in Blantyre township. This meant that not only was it in direct competition with non-African shops, but that it had to absorb overhead costs which peri-urban businesses did not: rent and rates. Further, Mvano had difficulty obtaining stock given immediate post-war quotas on imported goods. As early as 1945 the cooperative adviser, Campbell, had mentioned 'the general difficulty in obtaining trade goods' because of war-time shortages. He said that the natural tendency was for wholesalers to supply retail clients based on past performance.[116] But even Indian wholesalers were unable to supply all their usual buyers.[117] The post-war trade climate was too obdurate for African consumer cooperatives.

Government still held hope for producer and marketing cooperatives, but these enjoyed little success in Southern Province, mostly because planters dominated the agricultural sector. But in other spheres, Africans proved disinterested. In 1950, when the state was eager to increase the supply of meat to Blantyre-Limbe, the Director of Veterinary Services suggested a cooperative for butchers and meat dealers. This time, government was prepared to back up advisory assistance with monetary support of £200 for each cooperative member. Bingham discouraged the idea and cited 'technical cooperative reasons' to explain why a coop for butchers and meat dealers would fail. He said that a cooperative was bound to fail because it would be wrecked by those who 'stood out' — individuals who would not keep to the prices agreed upon by the collective and would undersell the cooperative. Butchers, too, were known to sell on credit, contrary to cooperative principles.[118] The only way for government to control meat prices and supply, in Bingham's view, was through a meat marketing board.[119]

An excellent example of 'standing out' is found in the case of the Lirangwe limemakers. After many years of government prompting, the limemakers agreed to

---

Lines Phambana, Maliana Village, T.A. Kapeni, Blantyre District, 11 June 1988; Interview 15, B.F. Chinseu, Ndeka, T.A. Chigaru, Blantyre District, 16 February 1987; Interview 7, James Mpunga, Newlands Inn, T.A. Kapeni, Blantyre District, 29 January 1987.

116 Campbell, 'Report on a visit to Nyasaland'.

117 MNA, 'Native Cooperative Societies', Ministry of Trade and Industry, Cooperative Division, File No. 14019/7883, Bingham to Chief Secretary, March 1949; see Power, 'Individual Enterprise', Chapter Three.

118 Interview 21 Isaac Peter Chisasa, Blantyre, Soche Forest Reserve, s/o Peter Chisasa, Head Butcher, Limbe Market, 14 March 1987; Interview 10 Ruth Ascroft.

119 MNA, Ministry of Trade and Industry, Cooperative Division 1415/11210, Bingham to Acting Director of Veterinary Services, 24 July 1950.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

form their own cooperative in 1955. It was short-lived. According to Zintambira, it failed because:

> ... the ones we chose to be the 'elders' were not well organised ... When the members gave money the elders were not taking care of it properly. Also they didn't go to look for orders. Sometimes when they get money or orders they did it on their own account.[120]

According to more than one informant, competition in this business during the 1940s and 1950s was cut-throat.[121] Initially, the more successful lime makers were reluctant to throw in their lot with the less accomplished. Poorer lime makers were dependent upon the affluent for transport and, to some extent, for their clientele. To cooperatise would have meant profit sharing for the more prosperous lime makers and this they were naturally loath to do. After the lime makers formed a cooperative, the wealthier lime makers were able to retain their dominance in the industry through positions on the cooperative board of directors (the 'elders'). In short, they were able to manipulate the cooperative to control access to clients and the use of collectively owned lime mills and transport facilities.[122]

To Bingham's frustration, Africans all over Blantyre and neighbouring districts, had demonstrated a consistent propensity to 'stand out'. In 1948, two Africans applied to begin an 'African Cinema Cooperative'. They claimed to have 20 persons willing to become members and £200 capital.[123] Bingham liked the idea of an African cinema, but balked at this proposal. He felt it 'the intention of the promoters to found a business with a closed membership simply in order to make money, rather than to provide a necessary public service'.[124] When the Nyasaland African Milling Company in Chichiri applied for cooperative assistance, Bingham replied that he could not assist them unless they accepted the principle of unlimited membership. This was not a cooperative according to Bingham, but a 'small group ... out to make money'.[125]

And indeed they were. Cooperatives only received a genuine hearing from Africans when some personal gain seemed possible from participation in them. As soon as cooperative 'ideals' were enunciated, a distinct lack of interest set in. As early as 1948, District Commissioner Haskard remarked:

> The Africans in Blantyre district appear to be better suited by temperament to run 'one man' enterprises than cooperative ventures and the success which has attended the commercial activities of numerous individuals engaged in brickmaking,

120 Interview 19 Nelson Evans Zintambira, Lirangwe, T.A. Chigaru, Blantyre District, 6 March 1987.

121 Interview 15 Bernard Francisco Chinseu, Ndeka, T.A. Chigaru, Blantyre District, 16 February 1987; Interview 16 Peter Jacob, Lirangwe, Blantyre District, 18 February 1987.

122 Personal communication Mr. M., 4 March 1987.

123 MNA, NSB3/3/6, F40, Hartwell Solomon and D.J. Tembo to Bingham, 8 July 1948.

124 Ibid., F42, Bingham to Rangeley, 5 August 1948.

125 Ibid., F62, K.C. Matupa, Secretary of the Nyasaland African Milling Company to Registrar of Cooperatives, 24 November 1948 and Bingham's marginal notes.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

limeburning, milling and the production of sawn timber does much to confirm this view.[126]

The real swan song of cooperation in Blantyre District, however, came in July 1951 with the dissolution of Mvano Stores.[127] Virtually every attempt at cooperation in Southern Province had failed. However, the evidence does not support Bingham's allegations of commercial incompetence. Cooperatives were foiled by the efforts of individual business people to control them for their personal economic advantage and because they were simply not viable in an economy dominated by non-African commercial interests.

Thrift and loan societies proved unattractive since they failed to provide immediate benefits to the target group — the African *petit bourgeoisie*. The choice to direct initial efforts at cooperation toward the 'detribalised' urban African was the result of a perverse paradox. Urbanisation was directly linked to 'detribalisation'. Yet officials like Bingham believed that it was the progressive mission-educated African who could grasp the 'modern' notion of cooperation and who possessed the skills to make a go of such a venture. Ironically, such structures were deemed 'appropriate' to Africa because of their similarity to 'traditional' structures; but these were the very structures which these men had already begun to abandon! If the colonial authorities hoped to turn the clock back on the development of an individualistic capitalist class through cooperative development they were mistaken.

By virtue of their rigid rules and regulations, consumer cooperatives did not have the flexibility to survive in a highly competitive trading environment. The experience of Mvano Stores illustrates this. It was unable to provide the same range of goods offered by the large non-African shops and too inflexible to compete with smaller African groceries which were able to offer consumers attractive purchasing arrangements. Moreover, African traders found nothing attractive about the prospect of merging their lots in cooperative ventures. The immediate abandonment of the proposed African Wholesale Cooperative provides strong evidence for this. Retail traders were keen to escape the wholesale stranglehold of Asian and European firms and an African wholesale outlet at first seemed to offer an attractive alternative. Nevertheless, when Bingham presented the reality of the cooperative structure, interest evaporated.

126 MNA, NS3/1/14, F4a, Annual Report Blantyre District 1948, p. 13. The Lirangwe Limemakers voted to form a cooperative in November 1955, but by 1956, they were still not registered. When I visited Lirangwe in 1987, I spoke with some of the coop's original 'members'. There was general agreement that the coop was short- lived, and from my personal observations, it was clear that there had been very little about it which was truly 'cooperative'. (MNA, GE/11/1/5504, Minutes of Limemakers from Lirangwe and Nkolombizo, 4 November 1955 and 11 December 1955.)

127 MNA, AS/6/5507, 'Order For Dissolution' — 16 April 1951. In June 1952 plans were made to establish another small consumers' cooperative in Blantyre. However, the founders were unable to find a suitable location. (Ibid., F28, 29, S.D. Chikafu, Secretary of the Blantyre Cooperative Society to District Commissioner, 25 June 1952 and President of Naperi Housing Committee to Blantyre Cooperative Society 2 July 1952.)

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions

Producer cooperatives were stymied by the tendency for more prosperous individuals (like the butchers, meat dealers, lime makers and brick makers) to use the cooperative structure to further their own ends. The more affluent African producers and traders demonstrated a natural hesitance to participate in such endeavours since the group orientation undercut their ability to respond quickly to market conditions. Moreover, they resisted profit sharing with other producers. Some entrepreneurs attempted to capitalize on government assistance for cooperation, but demonstrated no commitment to the 'ideals' of cooperation. Even the pairing of cooperative ideals with nationalist politics failed to overcome economic self-interest as Sangala discovered in 1947.

Bingham's despondency was palpable. It was a frustrated man who in April 1951 delivered the grim indictment of Southern Province Africans cited in the first paragraph of this piece. Bingham condemned these people for their lack of managerial ability and proclaimed this as the main reason for the failure of the cooperative movement in Southern Province. Clearly, the real problem was an almost total lack of receptivity to the ideals of cooperation. Africans lacked the appropriate 'community spirit'. Neither indirect rule nor cooperatives were able to guide Africans in the economic path demarcated by the state. Economic differentiation was already well under way and cooperation was unequal to its assigned task of fostering classless economic growth. The men of the Native Industrial Union and the African Industrial Society sought economic uplift through collective action, but they did so to enhance their chances of individual accumulation. The cooperators of the post-war period were impelled by the same concerns and, for this reason, rejected the cooperative option. Small business in the Southern Province of colonial Malawi originated as, developed as and remained an 'individual' affair.

This content downloaded by the authorized user from 192.168.52.73 on Wed, 21 Nov 2012 09:37:08 AM
All use subject to JSTOR Terms and Conditions